Richard Newsome

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Education

Georgetown University, Master of Global Human Development — Aug 2023 — May 2025
Specializations in Quantitative Analysis and Evaluation; Economic Policy for Development
Outstanding Scholar Award for highest GPA

Massachusetts Institute of Technology, Certificate in Data, Economics, and Development Policy — Aug 2020 — Apr 2021

Georgia Institute of Technology, Bachelor of Science in Physics — Aug 2015 — May 2019
Certificate in Biophysics
High honors

Publications

Working Papers and Works in Progress

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Locked Out: The Uneven Toll of COVID Border Closures in Sub-Saharan Africa
Newsome, Richard. (2026).

[Draft available here]

This investigation examines whether COVID-19 border closures had a disproportionate economic impact on landlocked Sub-Saharan African countries relative to their coastal counterparts. Exploiting the variation within border city pairs—urban centers whose footprints span international borders between one landlocked and one coastal country—a difference-in-differences analysis of nighttime light radiance finds that landlocked sides of border city pairs dimmed significantly following the widespread introduction of border closures in March 2020, relative to their coastal counterparts. This result is robust to controlling for country-specific containment policies and is consistent across alternative fixed effect specifications. Analysis of bilateral export data from UN Comtrade suggests a trade channel: landlocked countries' exports were significantly more sensitive to border closures in neighboring countries than were coastal countries, consistent with their structural dependence on cross-border transit routes for market access. Together, these findings provide some of the first causal evidence that landlocked countries' geographic disadvantage translates into measurably worse economic outcomes when neighboring countries restrict movement.

Fields of War: Conflict and Climate Vulnerability across the Syrian-Turkish Border
Newsome, Richard, Çağlar Özden, Hogeun Park, and Harris Selod. (2026). World Bank Policy Research Working Paper.

Submitted to AER: Insights

Contribution statement. Co-author. Contributed to research design, including identifying precipitation as a driver of impact heterogeneity and intruducing difference-in-discontinuity methodology; led the empirical analysis and created all figures, maps, and tables; wrote most of the manuscript.

[Draft available here]

Abstract. Conflicts can disrupt agricultural systems, amplifying the toll of war, especially in countries that have limited endowments of land suitable for agriculture. However, because of challenging endogeneity issues, the

literature fails to properly estimate the impacts of conflicts on land cultivation. Using a geographic difference-in-discontinuities approach across the Syrian-Turkish border, the study shows that the Syrian Civil War led to cropland abandonment equal to 8.1% of the Syrian area of analysis, alongside decreases in crop greenness of 0.67 standard deviations. These impacts differed in magnitude across years, as the largest reductions occurred in years with the lowest levels of rainfall, with losses in cropland as large as 22% of the area of analysis and reductions in crop greenness of up to 1.6 standard deviations occurring in years of extremely poor precipitation. This points to an increase in climate vulnerability, which likely resulted from the destruction of irrigation infrastructure in Syria.

Conference Papers

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A Mincerian Argument for Vocational Education

Newsome, Richard. (2025).

Presented at the Washington Consortium for Comparative and International Education and Training (WCCIET) at George Washington University in 2025.

[Paper available here] [Slides available here]

Abstract. This investigation uses computational simulation, with a modified Mincer equation to compare an educational model which allows individuals to split years of education between vocational and academic studies, to one which exclusively allows individuals to pursue academic education. While holding average output constant between models, in the vocational and academic studies model, inequality, as measured by the Gini coefficient, is shown to reduce by 29.5%, and poverty is shown to decrease by 37.6%, 62.0%, and 75.2% across FGT0, FGT1, and FGT2 metrics respectively, as compared to the academic-only educational model. Universal academic education, another educational model meant to address inequality and poverty, shows measures of inequality which are 28.1% lower, a poverty headcount index which is 75.1% lower, and a poverty gap which is 29.4% lower than those under the Vocational/Academic Mix model, however it achieves these results with 8.5% lower economic output, and with an FGT2 metric 51.1% higher than in the Vocational/Academic Mix model. These findings suggest that, compared to the Universal Academic Education model, the Vocational/Academic Mix model is better able to avert the most extreme forms of poverty, while avoiding any decrease in total output. This investigation demonstrates that high skill covariance and low valuation of vocational education increase metrics of poverty and inequality, and, in the case of undervaluation of vocational education, decrease average economic output. However, such effects are modest, and, in most circumstances, the Vocational/Academic Mix model outperforms the academic education-only model along relevant poverty and inequality metrics.

Economic Reports

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From Divide to Opportunity: AI, Jobs and Growth

World Bank. 2026. From Divide to Opportunity: AI, Jobs, and Growth. Middle East, North Africa, Afghanistan & Pakistan Economic Update (October 2026). World Bank.

Contribution statement. Performed background analysis, created most figures, and drafted text for the report's regional macroeconomic update, most of which focsued on the continuing impact of the Iran war on the region.

[Report available here]

Challenges of Conflict and Industrial Policy for Development

World Bank. 2026. Challenges of Conflict and Industrial Policy for Development. Middle East, North Africa, Afghanistan & Pakistan Economic Update (April 2026). World Bank.

Contribution statement. Performed background analysis, created figures, and drafted text throughout. In macroeconomic update (part 1) supported our understanding of the impacts of the Iran war in the region, particularly through channels of remittances, tourism, and energy exports. For the section on industrial policy (part 2), performed analysis of the prevalence, effectiveness, goals, and challenges of industrial policy in the region.

[Report available here]

Jobs and Women: Untapped Talent, Unrealized Growth
Gatti, Roberta, Çaglar Özden, Jesica Torres, Leila Baghdadi, Ernest Sergenti, Asif M. Islam, Isis Gaddis, Gianluca Mele, Sumin Chun, Francisco Parro, Mennatallah Emam Mousa, Angel Ramirez, Richard Newsome, and Ilias Suvanov. 2025. Jobs and Women: Untapped Talent, Unrealized Growth. Middle East, North Africa, Afghanistan, and Pakistan Economic Update (October), Washington, DC: World Bank.

Contribution statement. Assisted in the analysis and writing of the chapter on female labor force participation (part 2), performing all relevant analysis on introductory section on demographic change, and supporting throughout by creating figures and analytical pieces.

[Report available here]

Access, Usage, and Quality of Financial Tools in West Africa Countries
Apo-Oyin, Aramide, Adia Armstrong, Kyla Denwood, Isabelle Ick, Monica Khanal, Megan Kloeckner, Ruobin Liu, Kylee McVicker, Richard Newsome, Elizabeth Umutesi Queen, and Veronica Uribe-Kessler. (2024).

Contribution statement. Performed most of the initial data analysis and built tool to replicate analysis across countries in the region.

[Report available here]

Blog Posts
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Challenges of conflict and industrial policy for development
Gatti, Roberta, Çaglar Özden, Federico Bennett, Asif Islam, Sumin Chun, Rachel Yuting Fan, Nelly Elmallakh, Ilias Suvanov, and Richard Newsome (2026). Challenges of conflict and industrial policy for development. Economic Research Forum (ERF).
[Blog post available here]

Care for HIV-positive children can be affordable
Newsome, Richard (2026). Africa at LSE.
[Blog post available here]

Work and Research Experience

The World Bank, Research Assistant / Extended-Term Consultant — Jan 2027 — present
Office of the Chief Economist: Middle East, North Africa, Afghanistan and Pakistan

The World Bank, Research Assistant / Short-Term Consultant — May 2025 — Dec 2026
Office of the Chief Economist: Middle East, North Africa, Afghanistan and Pakistan

Georgetown University, Teaching Assistant — Aug 2024 — May 2026
GHDP 5012: Economics of Development: Poverty Alleviation — Dr. Andrew Dabalen
GHDP 5003: Quantitative Methods — Dr. Charles Udomsaph

Interamerican Development Bank, Graduate Capstone — Sep 2024 — Apr 2025

Fundação Getulio Vargas, Research Assistant — Jun 2024 — Aug 2024

DAI, Market Intelligence Analyst — Aug 2021 — Jul 2023

Peace Corps Mozambique, Education Volunteer — Aug 2019 — Mar 2020

Complex Rheology And Biomechanics (CRAB) Lab, Research Assistant — Jan 2017 — Jul 2019

Skills

Econometrics and Empirical Methods: Geographic regression discontinuity, difference-in-differences, difference-in-discontinuities, panel data methods, spatial analysis, causal inference

Quantitative and Mathematical Foundations: Advanced calculus, linear algebra, probability and statistics, scientific modeling, computational simulation, experimental design

Data and Geospatial Methods: Remote sensing and satellite data, GIS and spatial data construction, international trade and traffic, survey and household data, poverty measurement, data visualization, literature review

Software and Programming: Stata, R, Python, MATLAB, Julia, ArcGIS, Google Earth Engine, SQL, Excel

Communication and Writing: Scientific and technical writing, grant proposal drafting, synthesizing analytical concepts for non-technical audiences, cross-cultural communication, policy writing, conference presentation

Languages: English (native); Portuguese (professional working proficiency); Spanish (professional working proficiency); Mandarin Chinese (intermediate)